Possible Corn Pests

Farmer check sheet - Cabadbaran City, Agusan del Norte

Purpose

These 14 pests were found in Department of Agriculture (DA) corn guides and in studies from Caraga, Mindanao and the Philippines. No study has listed the corn pests of Cabadbaran City itself. This sheet asks local corn farmers which of these pests they have actually seen.

How to use

1. Show each pest page (pages 2-15) to the farmer.
2. Ask: "Have you seen this in your corn farm?" and what they call it locally.
3. Mark the answers on the answer sheet (page 16). Use a new answer sheet for each farmer.
4. If the farmer names a pest that is not in this sheet, write it in the space at the bottom of the answer sheet.

Pests in this sheet

1. Fall armyworm
2. Asian corn borer
3. Corn planthopper
4. Corn earworm
5. Corn aphid
6. Corn seedling maggot (shoot fly)
7. White grub
8. Armyworm
9. Common cutworm
10. Corn leafhopper
11. Thrips
12. Locust
13. Rats
14. Corn weevil ("bukbuk")

Photos are from iNaturalist (open licences) and the IP102 dataset (academic use); each photo is credited on its page. Pest descriptions follow the DA corn production guide.

1. Fall armyworm

Spodoptera frugiperda



Caterpillar



Caterpillar on a corn plant

What to look for

Ragged holes in young leaves and in the whorl, with sawdust-like droppings. The caterpillar has an upside-down "Y" mark on its head.

Why it is on this list

Recorded in Agusan del Norte: 2024 outbreak (DA Caraga).

Photo - Caterpillar: © Klaus Birkhofer (CC BY-NC), iNaturalist. https://www.inaturalist.org/observations/147600495
Photo - Caterpillar on a corn plant: © Helio Lourencini (CC BY), iNaturalist. https://www.inaturalist.org/observations/77866574

2. Asian corn borer

Ostrinia furnacalis



Adult moth



Pinhole damage on leaves

What to look for

Rows of pinholes on leaves. Holes in stalks, tassel base or ear stalk with sawdust-like droppings. Broken stalks; ears may drop.

Why it is on this list

Most damaging corn pest in the Philippines; top pest in Mindanao studies.

Photo - Adult moth: © Larney Grenfell (CC BY-NC), iNaturalist. https://www.inaturalist.org/observations/71477344
Photo - Pinhole damage on leaves: IP102 dataset (Wu et al., CVPR 2019), academic use. https://github.com/xpwu95/IP102

3. Corn planthopper

Peregrinus maidis



Adult on a leaf



Adult, close-up

What to look for

Stunted plants, leaves drying early, black sooty mould on leaves; in bad cases whole plants dry up. Small insects that jump when disturbed.

Why it is on this list

In the DA corn pest list; caused major corn damage in Mindanao (2004).

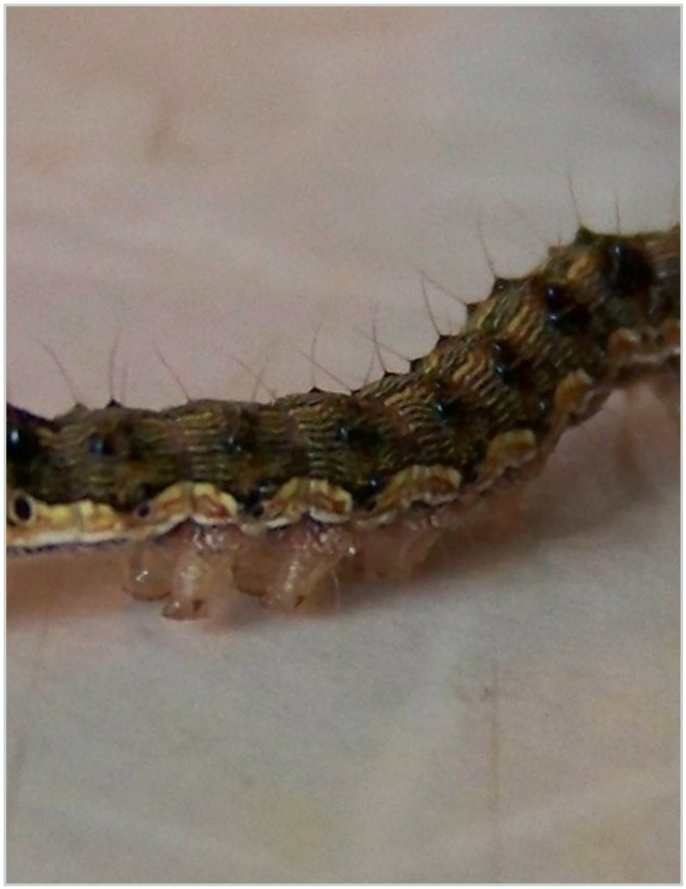
Photo - Adult on a leaf: © James Bailey (CC BY-NC), iNaturalist. https://www.inaturalist.org/observations/131224782
Photo - Adult, close-up: © annieliveoak (CC BY-NC), iNaturalist. https://www.inaturalist.org/observations/143695389

4. Corn earworm

Helicoverpa armigera



Caterpillar



Caterpillar

What to look for

Lines of feeding holes on leaves after they unfold. Cut silk and holes at the tip of the ear, from silking until the grain is soft.

Why it is on this list

In the DA corn pest list; recorded in Mindanao.

Photo - Caterpillar: © Corinna Herr (CC BY-NC), iNaturalist. https://www.inaturalist.org/observations/61506821
Photo - Caterpillar: © Yuliia Spinova (CC BY-NC-SA), iNaturalist. https://www.inaturalist.org/observations/63076260

5. Corn aphid

Rhopalosiphum maidis



Aphids on a corn tassel



Aphid colony on a leaf

What to look for

Colonies of small soft insects on leaves and tassels. Stunted plants; leaves black and sooty from the sticky honeydew they leave.

Why it is on this list

In the DA corn pest list; recorded in Mindanao.

Photo - Aphids on a corn tassel: no rights reserved, iNaturalist. https://www.inaturalist.org/observations/387328176
Photo - Aphid colony on a leaf: © Subramanian Sevgan (CC BY-NC), iNaturalist. https://www.inaturalist.org/observations/97904684

6. Corn seedling maggot (shoot fly)

Atherigona species



Adult fly



Adult fly

What to look for

Young leaves of seedlings turn yellow and rot; seedlings are stunted. The maggot is hidden inside the seedling; the adult is a small fly.

Why it is on this list

In the DA corn pest list; recorded in Mindanao.

Photo - Adult fly: © Katja Schulz (CC BY), iNaturalist. https://www.inaturalist.org/observations/107924838
Photo - Adult fly: © Katja Schulz (CC BY), iNaturalist. https://www.inaturalist.org/observations/63367479

7. White grub

Leucopholis species and other beetle grubs



Grub in the soil



Adult beetle

What to look for

Seedlings stunted and discoloured; roots eaten, so plants wilt and die. Fat, white, C-shaped grubs found in the soil when digging.

Why it is on this list

In the DA corn pest list.

Photo - Grub in the soil: IP102 dataset (Wu et al., CVPR 2019), academic use. https://github.com/xpwu95/IP102
Photo - Adult beetle: © John Edward Matulina Villasis (CC BY-NC), iNaturalist. https://www.inaturalist.org/observations/161108865

8. Armyworm

Mythimna separata



Caterpillar



Caterpillar

What to look for

Leaf edges eaten irregularly; in bad cases whole plants are stripped bare, leaving only the midrib.

Why it is on this list

In the DA corn pest list ("army worm").

Photo - Caterpillar: © flash8585 (CC BY-NC), iNaturalist. https://www.inaturalist.org/observations/253080447
Photo - Caterpillar: © Uwe Schneehagen (CC BY-SA), iNaturalist. https://www.inaturalist.org/observations/295614635

9. Common cutworm

Spodoptera litura



Caterpillar



Caterpillar on a leaf

What to look for

Young plants eaten bare; stems and leaves cut; leaves eaten down to the veins and midribs.

Why it is on this list

In the DA corn pest list.

Photo - Caterpillar: © johnallcock (CC BY-NC), iNaturalist. https://www.inaturalist.org/observations/13829771
Photo - Caterpillar on a leaf: © lq-yang (CC BY-NC), iNaturalist. https://www.inaturalist.org/observations/241403798

10. Corn leafhopper

Cicadulina bipunctata



Adults on a leaf



Adult, close-up

What to look for

Small, wedge-shaped insects on the leaves that hop away quickly when disturbed.

Why it is on this list

Recorded as a minor corn pest in a southern Mindanao study.

Photo - Adults on a leaf: © Chaym Turak (CC BY-NC), iNaturalist. https://www.inaturalist.org/observations/258697577
Photo - Adult, close-up: © ferran garcia mari (CC BY-NC), iNaturalist. https://www.inaturalist.org/observations/349182655

11. Thrips

Frankliniella and related species



Adult, magnified



Thrips on a leaf

What to look for

Very tiny, slender insects, easier to see with a magnifier. Silvery or pale streaks on the leaves where they feed.

Why it is on this list

Recorded as a minor corn pest in a southern Mindanao study.

Photo - Adult, magnified: © Gilles San Martin (CC BY-SA), iNaturalist. https://www.inaturalist.org/observations/140450065
Photo - Thrips on a leaf: © Craig Chaddock (CC BY-NC), iNaturalist. https://www.inaturalist.org/observations/45846903

12. Locust

Locusta migratoria



Adult



Adult

What to look for

Large grasshoppers, sometimes in swarms. Leaves eaten from the edges; in outbreaks whole fields can be stripped.

Why it is on this list

Caraga listed among regions reporting locusts (DOST-PCAARRD, 2024).

Photo - Adult: © Enrique Baquero (CC BY-NC), iNaturalist. https://www.inaturalist.org/observations/4314983
Photo - Adult: © Diego Rambert (CC BY-NC), iNaturalist. https://www.inaturalist.org/observations/340036617

13. Rats

Ricefield rat (Rattus tanezumi)



Ricefield rat



Ricefield rat

What to look for

Gnawed seedlings, stalks and ears; damage often starts near grassy or bamboo areas beside the field.

Why it is on this list

In the DA corn guide; can damage corn from planting to harvest and in storage.

Photo - Ricefield rat: © Jackson Hu (CC BY), iNaturalist. https://www.inaturalist.org/observations/14690925
Photo - Ricefield rat: © Cairina (CC BY-NC), iNaturalist. https://www.inaturalist.org/observations/262649010

14. Corn weevil ("bukbuk")

Sitophilus zeamais



Weevils on corn kernels



Adult, close-up

What to look for

Small dark beetles with long snouts in stored grain. Holes in the kernels and powdery grain.

Why it is on this list

In the DA corn guide: the most common pest of stored corn grain.

Photo - Weevils on corn kernels: © melanie stewart (CC BY-NC), iNaturalist. https://www.inaturalist.org/observations/372112868
Photo - Adult, close-up: © Shiwan Lu (CC BY-NC-SA), iNaturalist. https://www.inaturalist.org/observations/168814481

Answer sheet

Use one sheet per farmer.

Barangay: _____

Date: _____

Interviewer: _____

Farmer (optional): _____

Pest	Yes	No	Not sure	Local name / notes
1. Fall armyworm	☐	☐	☐	
2. Asian corn borer	☐	☐	☐	
3. Corn planthopper	☐	☐	☐	
4. Corn earworm	☐	☐	☐	
5. Corn aphid	☐	☐	☐	
6. Corn seedling maggot (shoot fly)	☐	☐	☐	
7. White grub	☐	☐	☐	
8. Armyworm	☐	☐	☐	
9. Common cutworm	☐	☐	☐	
10. Corn leafhopper	☐	☐	☐	
11. Thrips	☐	☐	☐	
12. Locust	☐	☐	☐	
13. Rats	☐	☐	☐	
14. Corn weevil ("bukbuk")	☐	☐	☐	

Other corn pests the farmer has seen (not in this sheet):

_____

_____

_____